

>> flexibility stretch

Flexibility is best understood as developing your own potential. Each body is unique, with its own set of bone shapes and muscle lengths. Take the challenge here to continue opening your entire body through the gateway of the hips. Hip suppleness is essential to spinal health.

The best way to achieve full body flexibility is to take on the challenge of the lower back, hips, and legs. Many people give up when they feel they are not flexible in the hamstrings, but remember that the body also comprises fascial tissue (see p.12) that, among other roles, ties the biomechanics of the upper body to that of the lower body. Now that you've done some loosening and lengthening of your whole body, it's time to focus on a deeper opening of your lower body. This sequence offers more moves that combine stretches with circular, rotational movements. It may require more modification than the first two workouts. Take heart. Challenging yourself with many different exercises will help you to identify your weak areas. There is always a back door into a movement—a way in which you can break the movement down and simply perform parts of it until they transform into old, familiar friends. Then you can join them together again and you're there!

The exercises

The Knee pumps prepare the legs and hips for the next moves. Part of my daily ritual, Knee pumps help to keep my knees and sciatic nerves—the long nerve along the backs of the legs—supple. There is no harm, and it is very beneficial, if you take the extra time to increase the repetitions to as many as 20 on each leg.

The Quad stretch, Thigh sweep, Fouetté stretch, and Figure 4 stretch are absolutely essential to my personal routine. Go slowly at first

>> tips for flexibility stretch

- **Suspend judgement** about your hip and leg stretch. Slow, steady persistence pays off. Look to yourself, and in yourself, for comparison.
- **Be sure to energize** your upper body as well as your lower body to create the necessary full-body connection.
- **Always use straps**, belts, or bands to modify when needed.
- **Changing the length of tight**, stiff muscles takes time. If your body type is over-flexible, tighten yourself and make the motion or position smaller so as not to over-stretch.

and make sure to observe the transitions from one movement to the next. Work hard to make these transitions smooth; they are actually additional stretches that help to give the sequence its three-dimensional element.

Challenge yourself to master the sequence by imagining you are coaching someone and have to demonstrate and explain each move to them. Being a teacher forces you to think about the nature of each movement and is the best way to clarify the movements in your own mind.